

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL

Former speaker: No quid pro quo

Powerful politician says he was surprised by Solis' assumption

By Jason Meisner, Megan Crepeau and Ray Long
Chicago Tribune

Former House Speaker Michael Madigan testified in his corruption trial Wednesday that he was taken aback when then-Ald. Daniel Solis told him over the phone that the developers of a West Loop condo tower understood “the quid pro quo” of hiring Madigan’s law firm.

“A great deal of surprise and concern,” Madigan said of the reaction in his head when Solis, who turned out to be working undercover for the FBI, uttered the phrase.

Solis seemed like a stand-up guy and straight arrow, and the comment continued to eat at him, the former speaker said under direct examination by his attorney, Daniel Collins.

“I decided that I wanted to have a face-to-face meeting with Mr. Solis to give me an opportunity to tell him that I would not be involved in a quid pro quo,” Madigan told the jury.

Solis’ secret video of that meeting, which was played for the jury earlier in the trial, captured Madigan telling Solis, the head of the influential Zoning Committee, that he “shouldn’t be talking like that” in front of developers.

Madigan said the look on Solis’ face “was such that it told me that he had gotten the message from me that I was not going to be involved in a quid pro quo.”

“He appeared to be very

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Inferno in L.A.

At least five killed as desperate residents flee massive fires fueled by hurricane-force winds

70,000 forced to evacuate so far, with blaze in Palisades the most destructive in city history



Raging flames destroy a home Wednesday in the Altadena section of Los Angeles County. MARIO TAMA/GETTY

By Jaimie Ding, Christopher Weber and Julie Watson
Associated Press

LOS ANGELES — Massive wildfires roaring through the Los Angeles area left neighborhoods in ruins Wednesday, killing at least five people and threatening landmarks made famous by Hollywood as desperate residents escaped through flames, hurricane-force winds and towering columns of smoke.

Three major blazes that erupted just a day earlier blanketed the city with a dangerous, thick cloud

of smoke and ash, and destroyed homes across the metropolitan area, from the Pacific Coast inland to Pasadena, home of the Rose Parade. A fire burning in the Pacific Palisades was the most destructive in the modern history of Los Angeles.

With thousands of firefighters already attacking the flames, the Los Angeles Fire Department put out a plea for off-duty and out-of-state firefighters to help. More than 1,000 structures were destroyed and numerous people were injured in the fires, including first responders, said Los Angeles County Fire Chief

Anthony Marrone.

“This morning, we woke up to a dark cloud over all of Los Angeles. But it is darkest for those who are most intimately impacted by these fires. It has been an immensely painful 24 hours,” LA County Supervisor Lindsey Horvath said.

At least 70,000 people were ordered to evacuate — a number that kept changing because evacuation orders were continually being issued, officials said. The flames marched toward heavily populated and affluent neighborhoods, including Calabasas and Santa Monica, home to many of California’s rich and famous.

Hollywood stars, including Mark Hamill, Mandy Moore and James Woods, were among those forced to flee.

“We are prioritizing life over everything else,” Sheriff Robert Luna said.

The fires have consumed about 22 square miles — about half the size of the city of San Francisco.

Jennie Girardo, a 39-year-old producer and director from Pasadena, said she was alarmed when her neighbor came to check on her.

“When I opened my door, it

Turn to Inferno, Page 10

GENERAL ASSEMBLY



State Sen. Lakesia Collins and state Sen. Graciela Guzman celebrate after being sworn in on Wednesday in Springfield. BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Calls for unity, naked partisanship mark inauguration ceremonies

By Jeremy Gorner and Addison Wright
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — The Illinois General Assembly launched a new two-year term on Wednesday with inauguration ceremonies that came on the heels of a tension-filled lame duck session marked by sparring between Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker and members of his own party.

Pritzker, who handled the task of swearing in the Senate in its newly-renovated statehouse chamber, acknowledged that the

new legislative session provides an opportunity for a fresh start in his relationship with legislative Democrats, including House Speaker Emanuel “Chris” Welch.

Pritzker unsuccessfully championed a measure to regulate hemp products during the lame duck session and accused at least one House Democrat of berating state agency workers who were called to a closed-door meeting to answer questions about the bill, which Welch eventually decided not to call it for a vote.

“Everyday’s a new day to do the right thing,” Pritzker said during

a news conference in his ceremonial office at the state Capitol after the Senate inauguration. “Look, people can make mistakes, and certainly mistakes were made and behavior was improper during that caucus. But people can make amends and we can all move on.”

Pritzker, Welch and Democratic Senate President Don Harmon have their work cut out for them in the coming months as they deal with issues led by a projected \$3.2 billion budget shortfall.

Turn to Assembly, Page 5

Negligence alleged in health center suicide

Lawsuits filed by family are another black eye for the state’s embattled social services agency

By Olivia Olander and Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

A state social services agency that has been under fire on several fronts, most recently in an internal audit that found shortcomings in how the agency responded to complaints, is accused of negligence in a pair of lawsuits filed by the family of a man who died by suicide in a west suburban mental health center.

Anthony Stringfellow Jr., 19, died by hanging on Feb. 7, 2023, at the Madden Mental Health Center near Maywood, according to two lawsuits that between them list the Illinois Department of Human Services, the state, the facility and individual care providers as defendants. His death occurred despite guide-

lines intended to make hospitals treating patients with mental illness safer for those who would attempt to harm themselves.

The negligence allegations are in a November 2023 complaint filed with the Illinois Court of Claims that names IDHS as a defendant and in an amended complaint filed in Cook County in June 2024 that names three doctors and a nurse as defendants.

An Illinois Auditor General’s Office report released in December detailed other issues at Madden, with investigators finding that while the center reported fewer allegations of mistreatment compared to other IDHS facilities, it had the lowest completion rate of employee training in the prevention and

Turn to Suicide, Page 2

Iowa State coach in mix for Bears job



The wide net the Bears are casting in search of the 19th coach in team history includes Iowa State’s Matt Campbell, according to multiple sources. Campbell guided the Cyclones to their first ever double-digit win season this year. **Chicago Sports**

TODAY’S WEATHER High 28 Low 21

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 16

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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